Fun in multiplayer environments

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Introduction

Recently, MrMillerPink published his article “Fun, Wins, and Losses” [1] referring to game design as an optimization tool that should be used in the MSTI. This brief article is, then, my way of following his advice and adding a second block of reflection on this point.

I had thought of conveying this as a comment, but I didn't want it to get lost among the many things that happen in comments; it seemed better, then, to have it published as an article where I could expand a bit more.

Thus, this article aims to point out certain limits that appear when using “game design” in multiplayer spaces, not because they are errors in themselves, but to narrow down the scope of this implication.

I. What is fun?

MrMillerPink cited Gabe Newell, to explain that fun is “The degrees to which the game recognizes and responds to the players choices and actions”. [1]

I find this definition very satisfactory and self-conclusive.

And yet, it seems to me that it appeared in a context that cannot be 100% transferred to server theories. Newell and his team were in the process of designing individual games, where their design encompasses: the environment's reaction, the physical reaction of movement, the reaction to the player's actions, the reactions of the player's enemies... etc.

This problem persists even when MrMillerPink uses the game Fortnite due to a difference I consider key. Minecraft servers, unlike other multiplayer games, do not base their fun and interaction on the design of the game per se, but rather reside in strategic forms of interacting where one cannot have prior information about what other players will do.

In plain English, this means that unlike games like Rainworld (2017), Risk of Rain 2 has a predetermined reaction model: Each entity operates under discrete states (Idle, Chase, Attack). Transitions occur only when specific conditions are met, such as “line of sight” or player proximity. [2]

This does not happen on Minecraft servers. Although this pattern of behaviors can be analyzed in the design of the game itself (as MrMillerPink himself does). The “medium” is different; a Minecraft server involves (or seeks to involve) other players whose reactions cannot be designed a priori as they can in a traditional video game.

This, I believe, means that the “fun” Newell talks about, and by extension what MrMillerPink talks about, is not the only one at play when applied to a strategic multiplayer environment. [1]

On the other hand, this responds to a distinction; a “pre-determined and farmable” recognition reaction is not the same as an interdependent recognition reaction subject to uncertainty.

This means that “Miller's fun” taken to its logical conclusion would lead players, after certain interactions, to learn what is fun in a given game and what is not. This also happens in Minecraft. The phenomenon of farms is basically the logical conclusion of learning the “mechanics” of the loops. Likewise, the automation of interactions with the game occurs because in Minecraft the recognition reaction is pre-determined, farmable, and repeatable under the same conditions.

In contrast, on a server, part of what attracts players and the fun they derive from what I call social fun: the fact of interacting with others. It may be in competitive contexts (winning/losing), but also in broader social contexts where an interaction leads to a reaction, but since both can meet again, that reaction has meaning beyond the initial fun and builds a “profile of meaning.”

Basically, repetition in interactions changes what is fun on a server. After all, you can't farm PvPs, friendships, connections, or economic systems.

Let's think of a player who builds an impressive farm. In Miller's framework, the game recognizes their action (the farm works). But if no one visits it, if no one comments, if no one integrates it into the server's narrative, does it really feel fun? Technical recognition exists, but social recognition does not. And it is the latter that builds community.

With this in mind, I believe this definition must be expanded for a server:

“Fun is the degrees to which the player feels that their actions and choices in the physical game are recognized and valued by the social world in a sustained manner over time.”

This change may seem small, but it is ultimately key. That there exists for the player a “profile of meaning” and that they have one for others as well.

For this, I refer not to my intuition, but to that of MrMillerPink himself in his previous article “A Talk About Anarchy”: [3]

“One of the greatest joys you can experience in life, is to be observed in a positive light by someone interested in you, whether it be family, friend or significant other; Not just in the sense of the core parts of your identity, but also the small things: habits, hobbies, and all the things you care about. It’s a shame that such validation, admiration and respect is sparse throughout society. You haven’t lived till someone likes the way you express yourself”.

This leads me to suggest that the greater the recognition and/or reactions a player's action produces in a social environment, the greater their satisfaction and “fun” within it. No one likes to be ignored.

This is the problem with “Miller's Fun” and my new proposal. And yet, there are still things I would like to cover.

II. The problem of uncertainty

Robert Axelrod in The Evolution of Cooperation (1984) [4] raised the problem of uncertainty, one that caused cooperative environments to fail and led to certain failures in maximizing the interests of those involved, paradoxically due to the belief that their interests were at risk. Paraphrasing Axelrod, the problem is as follows:

“The inability of actors to predict with certainty the intentions, behaviors, and reactions of their counterparts. This informational gap generates a risk of unilateral defection, where the fear of being exploited by the other (behavioral uncertainty) or ignorance about the duration of the relationship (temporal uncertainty) blocks collective action, turning cooperation into a dilemma of failed coordination unless there are signalling or reciprocity mechanisms that stabilize expectations.”

This is useful when talking about servers because the presence of “others” with their own agency and desires that we do not know leads to the uncertainty raised by Axelrod. We fear that others do not share our interests or that they do not want to interact/react to what we do in a “public” space, and as previously stated, it cannot be predicted. Likewise, we cannot take for granted, force, or predict that people will interact with us, or that they will do so positively.

When I apply this to Minecraft environments, I adhere to what MrMillerPink already mentioned. [3]

“My explanation of why the environment of Anarchy servers come about as such is that even if most players in the server don’t desire hostile interactions with one-another, the players who act chaos and destruction create incentives for players to not make efforts to socialize, and instead be suspicious of others whilst also acting viciously to protect themselves. This further alienates players who desire and make efforts towards amity, causing them to leave, making the dominant playerbase to consist of those who contribute to this antisocialness.”

What MrMillerPinker means here is that antisocial behavior is not the majority; instead, in most cases, it is simply the “most rational” action or the one that “makes the most sense” given an environment that favors it. In this sense, Axelrod's problem of uncertainty and the chain of events towards the antisocial that MrMillerPink proposes converge in what Shepsle and Weingast (1987) [5] called “Structure-induced equilibrium.”

That is, “in contexts of high strategic uncertainty, institutions act as incentive structures that alter the utility matrix of agents. The equilibrium is not just the result of individual or group preferences, but a product of the social environment which, by imposing restrictions and sanctions, reduces the possibilities of others' behavior, making them predictable and allowing actors to coordinate their actions under a cost-benefit structure stabilized by the norm itself.” [5]

If this is true (and MrMillerPink seems to recognize that it is), then both the uncertainty and the decision chain of other actors constitute the “Environment” or “structure” that provides incentives or sanctions for players' actions. In an environment where one does not know what reaction actions cause, nor which players are “good or bad,” the individual player or group tend to move away as it is the action that best protects their own interests in the face of high uncertainty.

This is why, for example, players on servers tend to move away from each other even when resources for survival are present in abundance.

This phenomenon occurs even more on servers of an anarchic nature, as we would expect if what MrMillerPink proposes is true. [3]

III. Minecraft and Fortnite

This problem in general also serves to differentiate interaction and fun in Minecraft and Fortnite. In the latter, players literally fall from the sky on a bus with their expectations clear; there are 100 players and only one can be alive. There is no uncertainty about what others want to do, there are no “other things” to do in the meantime; the storm closes the available space, incentivizing movement towards the center. The structure induces an equilibrium where the dominant action is to kill each other.

There may be small variations: if there is a very good player, some might target them in a temporary alliance. But as MrMillerPink [1] said in his latest article, people like to win, they like (even more) the reward for winning. Fortnite's structure therefore demands that any alliance be unstable, short, conditional, and purely utilitarian. Moreover, it is most likely that 99.9% of Fortnite players will never meet or never meet in a truly meaningful way, which makes it easier to betray, lie, deceive, flee, or target. If it were different and players had to play together again for a few matches, for example, then we would expect to see fewer of these individualistic behaviors because acting that way would be frowned upon and could even lead to being targeted, which would take away the fun.

In contrast, a Minecraft server is already in a different structural state; fun does not derive from purely individual achievements (surviving, doing things to progress, etc.). It is also founded on good coexistence, on fun, meaningful interactions/reactions (as we saw in the previous chapter). Likewise, Minecraft's design allows, beyond physical limitations, freedom to shape the opportunity structure on a server. Minecraft does not have “one objective”; there are perhaps incentives to beat the game and progress materially, but beyond that, it does not have Fortnite's structure of “you kill or you lose.” This allows for the existence of anarchic servers, where the structure leads to antisocial behaviors [3], but also a great variety of servers that can propose an explicit objective like Fortnite, or that can set rules to avoid outcomes they don't like.

This leads me to one of the solutions (or rather considerations) from Shepsle and Weingast's (1987) [5] theory, who considered that in their model, institutions not only limit available options but also act as mechanisms for reducing strategic uncertainty by stabilizing expectations and shaping the cost-benefit structure for rational actors. For our purpose: Institutions are Rules, customs, and social norms.

These considerations lead me to think that what MrMillerPink called “game design” could be adapted to a Minecraft server as “institutional design” because it is the rules that shape what players do or do not do, and allow for the “design” of reactions and recognition that respond to the player's decisions and actions.

Conclusion

In the end, all of this points to a discomfort worth holding onto. Game design gives us powerful tools, but when we transfer them to multiplayer servers, something resists. We cannot program one player's reaction to another, neither farm friendships nor automate respect.

And yet, what we cannot program is precisely what matters most.

Fun on a server is not just that the game responds to our actions. It's that someone else sees them, remembers them, values them. It's that awkward and wonderful moment when a stranger comments on your build, or when your name appears in a conversation you weren't expecting. It is, as Miller himself said before, being observed by someone who cares about how you express yourself.

The problem is that this kind of recognition cannot be directly designed. You can only design the conditions for it to occur. This is, rules that make others' behavior predictable, spaces that invite interaction, institutions that punish betrayal and reward trust. Institutional design prepares the soil for community to decide to grow.

And yet, uncertainty will always remain; The uncertainty about whether the other will cooperate or betray. The uncertainty about whether our actions will be recognized or ignored. This uncertainty is what I consider a condition of possibility. Because if we could predict everything, if every interaction were guaranteed, then recognition would lose its value. It would be like just another farm: efficient, predictable, and empty.

Perhaps that's why the servers that last are not always the most “Game immersed” or even the best to play on. The servers that last the most are those where, despite the uncertainty, people keep choosing to form a connection.

References

[1] MrMillerPink, 2026, *FUN, WINS, AND LOSSES*, Institute of Minecraft Studies

[2] Hopoo Games, 2019, *How moving from 2D to 3D shaped the design of Risk of Rain 2*, https://www.gamedeveloper.com/design/how-moving-from-2d-to-3d-shaped-the-design-of-i-risk-of-rain-2-i-

[3] MrMillerPink, 2026, *A Talk About Anarchy*, Institute of Minecraft Studies

[4] Axelrod, R., 1984, *The Evolution of Cooperation*

[5] Shepsle, K. A., & Weingast, B. R., 1987, *The Institutional Foundations of Committee Power*, The American Political Science Journal